

The Hidden Valence

Why Nothing We Call Good Or Bad Is Separate From Feeling

A sequel to The Case for Hedonic Primacy

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Abstract

In an earlier paper, *The Case for Hedonic Primacy*, I argued that positive valence is the only thing that is intrinsically good, and negative valence the only thing that is intrinsically bad. That paper stated the claim and traced its consequences. What it never did was the one thing that would make the claim impossible to escape. It did not take the things we believe to be valuable in their own right, one at a time — money, status, love, truth, meaning, achievement, beauty, justice, freedom, health, power, legacy, and life itself — and show of each that the value we find in it is feeling, and nothing but feeling, wearing a disguise. That demonstration is the work of this paper. The instrument is a single test, which I call the subtraction test, and it can be run on any candidate good. Hold the thing fully present, remove only the feeling, and ask whether anyone would still want what is left. I run the test in the open, on the hardest cases I can find, and watch them fall one after another. None survives. I then owe an account of why, if this is so, almost no one sees it, and I give one; a truth denied by nearly everyone needs its denial explained rather than merely deplored. The illusion that some values stand apart from feeling is not stupidity. It is the predictable joint product of four things: an evolved nervous system that hides its own machinery, a world in which a good and the feeling it brings almost never come apart, a language built to name shared objects rather than the private subject who feels them, and a calm reflective stance that lacks access to the very evidence in question. With the reduction in hand, I ground it in the documented neuroscience of reward and adaptation, naming the specific physical mechanisms by which the brain cancels sustained pleasure, and I argue that because they are mechanisms they can be edited. From there the consequences run further than the first paper carried them: into the identity of the being who would benefit from a hedonic future, into the population ethics of how much experience there should be and for whom, into the role freedom keeps after suffering is gone, indispensable yet temporary, lasting only until valence itself is fully understood, into a frankly-labelled speculation about the possible scale of experience, and at last into the single empirical question on which all the rest waits, which is what valence physically is. I hold the central claim to be true. Not as a hypothesis awaiting

confirmation, but as the floor every other value has been standing on the whole time, without once looking down.

A Note on This Paper and the Last One

This is a sequel, and it can stand alone, though it aims at a different target than its predecessor. The first paper made the case that valence is what matters and described the world that follows once you take that seriously. The most common response, and it came from careful readers rather than careless ones, was not that the claim is false but that it is too strong. Some things, the objection went, are good for reasons that have nothing to do with how they feel. Surely truth is worth having even when it hurts. Surely love is more than a warm sensation. Surely a just outcome is good whether or not anyone is left to enjoy it. This paper is my answer, and the answer is not a retreat to something smaller. It is the reverse. I mean to show that every one of those supposedly feeling-independent goods is feeling in a coat, and that the coat is so finely tailored, for reasons I can name precisely, that we have spent our whole lives mistaking it for the body underneath.

I acknowledge again, as I did before, my debt to David Pearce's *The Hedonistic Imperative* and to the work of Andrés Gómez Emilsson at the Qualia Research Institute, whose conclusions I reached on my own and then found waiting for me in print. What this paper adds lies in three places: the systematic reduction that makes up its first and largest part, the explicit grounding of the adaptation argument in published neuroscience, and the pressing of the consequences, among them the identity of the beneficiary, the population question, and the surviving role of freedom, further than I have seen them taken. Where I repeat myself, I do it on purpose, because the thing has not yet been said plainly enough to stay said. And one rule of method holds throughout. Where I assert a fact about the brain, it comes from the peer-reviewed literature and is cited. Where I speculate, I say so in the plainest words I have, and I wall the speculation off from the argument that does not lean on it.

Part I — The Hidden Valence

1. The Illusion of Separate Goods

Here is a belief almost everyone holds and almost no one examines: that some things are valuable in themselves, quite apart from how they make anyone feel. Ask a thoughtful person whether they would rather hold a true belief or a comforting false one, and most will choose the true one, even when the truth is the one that hurts. Ask whether love is merely a pleasant sensation, and you will give offence. Ask whether a fair outcome still matters when no one is left to enjoy it, and the answer comes back as though the question were idle: of course it does. The conviction that value arrives in two grades, a lower kind that is about feeling and a higher, more serious kind that is not, is among the most stable intuitions human beings have.

It is also false. I am going to spend this part of the paper taking it apart, not from the top down by argument, but from the bottom up by inspection, one case at a time, until there are no counterexamples left to reach for.

Precision matters here, because the claim is easy to soften into something everyone already grants, and a claim everyone grants is a dull one. I am not saying that feelings are important, or very important, or the most important thing on a list of several. I am saying that feeling is the only thing that has ever mattered, for good or for ill; that every other candidate for value is either a mechanism that delivers feeling or a signal that tracks it; and that when the candidate is pruned away from the feeling, which ordinary life almost never permits but thought can stage at will, the value leaves with the feeling, every time, without one exception. This is not a remark about what is usually so, or mostly so. It is a claim about what value is.

The claim sounds extreme only because we have never been made to look. In the life we actually live, the things we value and the feelings they produce come bound together almost without exception. The money arrives, and the relief arrives in the same instant. The person we love walks in, and the warmth walks in alongside. We learn the world through this steady co-occurrence, and co-occurrence is precisely the condition under which two things can never be told apart, since the one is never given without the other. To find out that they are two, you have to prise them apart on purpose. That is the whole of my method, and I begin it now.

2. The Subtraction Test

The instrument is simple, and it stays the same instrument from the first case to the last, which is part of why I trust it. Take anything, X, that you believe is valuable in its own right. Now perform in thought an operation that life will never perform for you. Hold X completely fixed and present. Change nothing whatever about it. But set the feeling of every conscious being toward X, permanently and beyond any appeal, to zero. Not to faint. To nothing. Then ask the question. Does anyone still want X? Does anyone reach for it, guard it, mourn its loss, build a life around it? If the honest answer is no, if X with the feeling drained out of it is something not one person would cross a room to reach, then the value you had credited to X was never sitting in X at all. It was in the feeling, and X was the thing that carried the feeling to you. This is the subtraction test. The rest of Part I is nothing but running it, slowly and out loud, on exactly the cases where you are most certain it will break.

A mirror-image version is worth stating once, since it catches the same fact from the far side. Call it the addition test. Remove X entirely, but deliver in full the feeling that X would have produced, complete and indistinguishable from within. Is anyone left wanting? In almost every case, no. Where it looks as though the answer might be yes, we will have found the single genuine pressure point on the whole view, which is Nozick's experience machine, and I will not slip past it but will meet it head-on in section five. For now, keep the plain version in hand. Value tracks the feeling and not the thing, every time the two are pulled apart. Watch it happen.

3. The Goods, Dissolved

One word about method before the examples, because it governs what they prove. For each good I examine, I reach for the feeling that most people attach to it. The argument does not depend on your sharing that particular attachment, and it matters that you see why. The subtraction test runs on whatever you happen to value, dropped in wherever I have set my own example. Perhaps your peak is not the moment of understanding but the moment a piece of music finally opens; not the first sight of your child but the summit of a hard climb; not prayer but sex; not the applause but the quiet after the work is done. Then run the test on yours. Substitute freely. You will arrive where I arrive, every time, because the test is indifferent to what the good is. It asks one thing only, whether the value outlasts the removal of the feeling, and the value never does.

That convergence is not a weakness in my examples, something I am quietly asking you to forgive. It is the strongest single piece of evidence in the paper. Consider what it means that a thousand people, each beginning from a wholly different thing they would have sworn was valuable in its own right — one from money, one from justice, one from a god, one from a lover, one from a symphony — all land on the identical result the instant they perform the same subtraction. If these goods were genuinely separate and irreducible, the subtraction would behave differently in each hand. Strip the feeling from justice and the justice-value would stand there untouched; strip it from music and the music-value would collapse; and we would be left with a patchwork, some goods feeling-dependent and others not. There is no patchwork. There is total uniformity. Every good, however unlike the rest in outward shape, empties through the same opening the moment feeling is withdrawn. That is precisely what we should expect if they were never separate goods to begin with, but one good in a thousand costumes. The sheer variety of what moves us is therefore not noise for the argument to apologise for. It is the control group. It is the reason we can be confident the common factor is real, because the experiment varies everything else and holds only the feeling fixed, and still the value follows the feeling without a single exception. So when I reach for an example you do not share, do not file the section away as one that fails to apply to you. Set your own good in its place and watch the same collapse occur. That you can always do this, and that it always comes out the same, is the entire proof in miniature.

3.1 Money

Start with the easy one, because it warms up the method. No human being has ever wanted money. They have wanted what money is for. No one on a deathbed asks to see the bank balance; no one has ever held a banknote and felt that the paper itself was the point. What we want is the exhale in the week the rent finally clears, the loosening of the knot that had been sitting in the stomach the whole time it did not. We want the ease that moves in where the worry was, the small bright lift of being looked up to in whatever form that takes for a given person, the precise relief of knowing that if the worst arrives we can cover it. The miser looks like the counterexample: the man who seems to love the money itself, who hoards it, spends none of it, and would not trade a coin for any comfort it could buy. But the miser is not the exception. He is the purest confirmation the thesis has. Watch what he is actually doing as he counts the hoard. He is feeling the warm flush of safety, the swell of the pile growing, the dread of want held off at arm's length. Now give that same miser a number that climbs on a screen he entirely believes in, but rig it so the rising number produces in him

no safety, no pride, no relief, nothing felt at all, and he stops counting at once. He has no reason left to continue, because the only thing he was ever after was the feeling the climbing number gave him. So the miser has not escaped the rule that money is wanted for its feeling. He has done something far more revealing: he has stripped money down until feeling is the only thing left inside it, and fallen in love with the residue. Set a vault of gold on an island where you will die no matter what you do with it, and the gold is worth precisely nothing, because nothing downstream of it will ever be felt. Money is the most honest case because we already half-know the answer; we call it a means and not an end. It is frozen feeling, valence stored up and not yet spent. Subtract the feeling it can buy, and not one person alive would carry it across the street.

3.2 Status and recognition

Status feels more dignified than money and dissolves just as fast. Why does praise warm us, and being ignored sting? Run the test. Imagine you are admired, genuinely and widely, but the admiration is spoken only in a language you will never hear, in a country you will never visit, and you never once learn that it exists. Has anything good happened to you? Nothing has happened to you at all. Now run it backward. You are privately, secretly held in contempt by people who smile to your face, and you never find out. Have you been harmed? Not in any way you will ever feel. The hardest case for status is the one that looks as though it severs recognition from experience completely: the soldier who dies for a glory he will never witness, the artist who starves now to be remembered after death. Surely here, at last, is a person trading real feeling for a recognition he will not be alive to collect. But look at what is moving him while he is still alive, because the living present is the only place anything moves anyone. He feels, now, in advance, the warm imagined light of the monument, the swell of his name outlasting him. The anticipated remembrance arrives in the present as a present glow, and it is that glow he is buying with his life. Take it away. Convince him, truly, that he will not be remembered, or strip out his capacity to feel anything whatever about the prospect, and his willingness to die for it leaves with the feeling, every time. He was never reaching across the grave to gather in a recognition. He was warming himself, here, on this side of it, at the fire of imagining it. Status reaches you, and matters to you, exactly to the degree that it becomes a feeling somewhere inside your experience, and not by one degree more. It is a feeling-delivery system in the costume of a social fact.

3.3 Love

Now the case that nearly everyone is certain refutes me, and the one I most want to get right, because to get it wrong would be to play the fool about what many people hold to be the most important thing in their lives. Love, surely, is not a sensation. Surely to reduce it to feeling is to insult it. So look at what love actually is from the inside, honestly, with the reverence we are trained to perform set aside for a moment. The bond is felt, or it is nothing: the warmth of their presence in the room, the particular hollowness of the house in the hours they are gone, the animal safety of being held by them, the involuntary lift when their name lights up the phone. Strip every one of those feelings out. Leave the person, the long history, the shared lease, the word 'love' still written in the anniversary card, but take away all the warmth, all the longing, all the comfort, the whole of the ache and the gladness. What

remains is not a purer, higher love that has finally shed its sensory clutter. What remains is a contract between two strangers who happen to share an address.

There is a subtler objection, and it is the one that genuinely earns an answer, because it appears to show love surviving in the total absence of feeling. I love my child at three in the morning, when I feel nothing toward them but exhaustion, a flicker of resentment, and the wish to be back asleep. Surely the love is still there even when the warm feeling is not. Yes, it is, and admitting so costs the claim nothing, once we are careful about what love is. Love is not a continuous glow that has to be relit in every waking second on pain of going out. It is a standing structure, a disposition built into your nervous system, such that this one particular person's wellbeing reliably becomes your own across the whole long arc of a life. The exhausted parent at three in the morning is not feeling the glow, but the structure is fully intact, and it can be demonstrated in a heartbeat: let a real threat to the child appear in that very moment, and the exhaustion vanishes and the entire organism is abruptly feeling, violently, on the child's behalf. What 'persists' through the grey hour is exactly that readiness, the shape of what would be felt the instant the conditions called for it, and it pays out in felt valence again and again across the years, in the lift when they laugh, the fear when they are sick, the ache the day they leave home. Now subtract not merely the present glow but the entire disposition. Arrange it so that this person's fate, under any conditions whatever, in joy or in mortal danger, never moves you, never could move you, produces in you no feeling now and none ever. You have not arrived at a deeper, feeling-free love that has at last dropped its disguise. You have arrived at a stranger. The love was the standing capacity for their life to register in yours as feeling. Remove that capacity, and nothing anyone would recognise as love is left behind.

The strongest objection lives right here, and it deserves to be put at full force. But I would suffer for them. I would take their pain into myself if I could. Does that not prove I value something above my own feeling? No. And this is the heart of the whole case: it is not the exception to the rule, it is the rule stated at its most beautiful. You would suffer for them because their wellbeing has gotten inside your own valence. Their joy lands in you as joy. Their suffering lands in you as suffering. That is what it is to love someone, that their inner weather has become part of your own. Empathy is not a moral ornament fastened on top of feeling. It is feeling extended, one nervous system's states registering directly inside another. So when you sacrifice for the person you love, you are not overriding your hedonic interest at all. You are obeying it, because theirs and yours have quietly merged into a single account. And if you now ask why another being's feeling should move you as though it were your own, hold on to the question, because it has an answer, and the answer is the whole subject of the second part of this paper. Love is the first place in an ordinary life where the self turns out, without ever announcing it, to be larger than the body it is wearing.

3.4 Truth and knowledge

This is the hardest case, the one a philosopher will fight hardest to keep, so I will give it the room it deserves. Surely, the objection runs, we value truth for its own sake. The scientist wants to know how the universe works whether or not the knowing makes her happy; we would all rather hold a hard truth than a soft lie. Begin with what cannot be denied: the desire to know is itself a feeling. Curiosity is a real state, a low and specific tension, an itch

somewhere in the mind, and understanding is the relief of it, the click when a thing finally falls into place, the small clean pleasure of the answer landing. Anyone who has lain awake unable to stop turning a question over knows in the body that not-knowing is a discomfort and that knowing is its resolution. So far the reduction is easy.

Now push on the residue, the part that feels as though it survives. Imagine a truth whose effects you will never feel, that you will never act on, and that you will never even know you possess: a fact deposited straight into your brain in a sealed compartment you can never open, with no downstream consequence for any experience you will ever have, yours or anyone else's. Have you been given something valuable? You have been given nothing at all, because you cannot tell, from the inside, the difference between holding it and not. Knowledge that touches no experience anywhere is as inert as a book written in a language no one will ever read, shelved in a vault no one will ever open, in a universe with no one left alive to read it. The value of truth is the whole difference it makes to how things feel: the relief of understanding, the power to act and so to shape what will be felt later, the awe of seeing how the world is actually put together. For a mind built to be moved by it, that awe can be among the most intense states it ever enters, even as the next person finds their own summits somewhere else entirely. There is a genuine apparent counterexample folded into this case, the person who knowingly chooses a painful truth over a blissful illusion, and I have promised not to dodge it. I will meet it in section five, on its own ground. But the ordinary reverence for truth-in-itself does not survive the subtraction. Take the feeling out of every truth, and no one would lift a finger to learn a thing.

3.5 Meaning and purpose

People will give up pleasure for meaning, and they take this as proof that meaning is a separate and higher good. It is proof of the reverse, once you notice what meaning is. Meaning is a feeling, a specific and powerful one: the felt sense that your life and your actions matter, that you belong to something whose weight you can register from the inside. For many people it is among the most motivating states they ever enter, which is exactly why they will trade lower pleasures away to reach it. They are trading a small feeling for a large one, not a feeling for a non-feeling. The test settles the matter at once. Imagine a life that is meaningful by every external measure, world-historically important, given over to a great cause, certified significant by the universe itself, and yet feels, from the inside, like nothing whatever: grey, flat, vacant, no sense of purpose ever once arriving in experience. Would anyone want that life? No one would take it. What a person wants when they want meaning is the feeling of meaning, and a meaning guaranteed never to be felt is not even a consolation prize. It is not a prize at all.

3.6 Achievement and mastery

The summit, the finished work, the years of practice resolving at last into a skill that obeys you: these feel like goods that stand on their own, monuments that would matter even if no one felt a thing about them. They would not. An achievement that no one ever experiences as an achievement, not the achiever, who feels no pride and no satisfaction and no quiet sense of completion, and not any witness, who feels no admiration, is simply an event, a rearrangement of matter with no one for whom it registers as good. The pride of the

craftsman, the runner's wordless arrival at the line, the particular satisfaction of a hard thing done well, that is the entire content of the value. Subtract it, and the achievement is an entry in a logbook that warms no one.

3.7 Beauty and art

Beauty seems to live out in the world, in the sunset and the symphony, independent of any observer. It does not. For one person it is the chill down the spine at the held note; for another, the stillness that comes over the body in front of a mountain; for a third, the strange satisfaction of an elegant proof; and for some there is no bodily thrill at all, only a quiet gladness. Beauty is the name we give to a certain kind of valence that certain arrangements of the world produce in a mind built, in its own particular way, to be moved by them. The canvas is pigment. The chord is air pressure. Neither is beautiful in the dark with no one there. A sunset on a planet that no conscious being will ever see is not a wasted beauty; it is photons. Remove every feeling that art and nature call up in us, and what is left is vibrating air and reflected light, and not one reason on earth to prefer the gallery to the parking lot.

3.8 Morality and justice

This is the case I least want to get wrong, because mishandling it makes the whole view sound monstrous, as though I were announcing that right and wrong are illusions and anything goes so long as it feels good. I am saying the reverse of that. Ask why we want justice and recoil from cruelty. We recoil from cruelty because cruelty is suffering: the victim's, vividly, and then our own, arriving through the empathic channel that makes another creature's pain land inside us as pain. We want fairness because unfairness rankles, a real and specific negative state, and fairness is what settles it. Now strip the feeling out of an entire moral situation. Imagine an injustice that causes no suffering to anyone, that no being experiences as bad in any way, now or ever, whether directly or through empathy. You will find you cannot even say what was supposed to be wrong with it. The wrongness had nowhere to live except in experience, and you have just evicted it.

Far from dissolving morality, this is the only thing that has ever made it solid. The philosopher J. L. Mackie gave what he called the 'argument from queerness', using 'queer' in the older sense it carried in 1977, meaning strange or anomalous. His point was that objective moral facts, if they existed as features of the world independent of any mind, would have to be entities of a very strange sort, unlike anything else in the universe and detectable by no faculty we can describe. He was right that such free-floating facts are nowhere to be found. But valence-grounded badness is not strange in his sense at all. It is the most locatable thing there is: it is somewhere, in someone, felt. The suffering of a tortured creature is not wrong because of a non-natural property hovering above the scene that a sufficiently refined intuition might pick up. It is wrong because it is suffering, and suffering is the very substance of badness, open to inspection by the only instrument that has ever detected value, a nervous system. So when the critic objects that on my view we could surely justify torturing an innocent if it pleased enough onlookers, the answer is built into the framework rather than bolted on after the fact. The intensity of severe suffering is not a quantity a crowd's mild pleasures can outvote; the relief of suffering takes priority over the addition of pleasure; and, as the second part of this paper will argue, the victim is not, at the deepest level, anyone other

than the onlookers themselves. Morality is the management of valence across all who can feel. That is not a debunking of ethics. It is its foundation, set down at last on the only ground able to bear the weight.

3.9 Freedom, life, and the sacred

Three more, briefly, because each one reduces by the same motion, and two of them will return later with more to say. Freedom: we prize it because to be coerced, caged, or overridden feels intolerable, and because room to act is the precondition of shaping our own future feeling. A freedom that produced no good feeling and guarded against no bad one, autonomy exercised by a being able to feel nothing whatever, would be an empty formality. Freedom does keep one further role even past that point, an indispensable one, but the role is instrumental, and I take it up in section thirteen. Life: we cling to it because living feels like something and we want more of that something, and because death threatens the end of all feeling at once. Even the raw survival instinct is valence at its root; it is fear, the oldest and most reliable negative state evolution ever built. The sacred: for those who have it, religious experience carries some of the most intense positive valence a human being ever reports, the awe, the oceanic peace, the ecstasy of the mystics, the peace that is said to pass understanding. I do not say this to mock faith. I say it to locate the sacred exactly where the faithful themselves feel it, which is in experience, among the most overwhelming feelings a person can have. Subtract the feeling from the holy, and what is left is a building and a book.

3.10 The same motion, applied quickly

Once the method is in hand, the remaining candidates fall in a sentence apiece, and it is worth running them off in quick succession so you can feel how general the result is. Health: we do not want a well-maintained body as an abstract state of affairs; we want the vitality that feels good, and the freedom from the pain, the fear, and the foreclosed futures that illness drags in with it. A perfectly healthy body that produced and enabled no feeling would be a machine in excellent repair with no one home in it. Power and control: what we want is the felt security of not being at another's mercy, and the pleasure of efficacy, set against the specific dread of helplessness; power held by a being who felt nothing about keeping it or losing it would be an inert capacity that no one valued. Novelty and adventure: we chase the new because sameness dulls the signal, which is the brain's own adaptation, examined in detail in the next part of this paper, and the new re-lights it; novelty is a feeling-renewal strategy, prized for the aliveness it gives back. Comfort barely needs the test at all, since comfort simply is a mild, relieving positive feeling, and no one has ever wanted a comfort that no one feels. And legacy, the most self-transcending-seeming of them all, the wish that something of us outlast us and that our children flourish once we are gone. We want our children's flourishing because it lands in us as joy now, through the very same empathic channel as love, and because we feel, here in the present, the warmth of imagining it. A legacy that produced no feeling in anyone, not in us and not in those who come after, is a name cut into a stone that no one reads. Here, as with love, the reduction does not cheapen the wish. It locates it, and it points ahead to the part of this paper where the line between 'my children' and 'me' turns out to be far thinner than the body makes it look.

4. Why the Illusion Is So Convincing

If the reduction is this clean, a fair reader will press the obvious question. Then why does nearly everyone, including brilliant people who have turned the matter over for a lifetime, believe so firmly that some goods stand apart from feeling? If I am right, I owe an account of the error, and the account has to explain it rather than merely sneer at it. There are, I think, four reasons the illusion is not only common but very nearly irresistible. Once you can see all four at work, the spell loosens, because you can feel the machinery that was manufacturing it.

The first is co-occurrence, which I have mentioned and will now name as a principle. You can only learn that two things are distinct if you sometimes meet one without the other. In ordinary life the external good and the feeling it brings travel together almost without exception. The money comes with the relief. The friend comes with the warmth. The true belief comes with the click of understanding. Because we never encounter the one shorn of the other, we never receive the single lesson that would teach us they are two. So we fuse them into one perceived object and point at the outer half, for the plain reason that the outer half is the half we can see and name.

The second reason runs deeper, and I think it is the decisive one. Evolution hid the feeling-machinery from us on purpose. A nervous system is built to keep a body alive and reproducing, and feelings are the steering signal it uses to do the steering: pain to snatch the hand from the fire, hunger to drive the search for food, the warmth of belonging to hold the animal close to its tribe. Now comes the crucial design constraint. A creature that grasped that the feeling was the real target, and that the food and the tribe were only the means to it, would be a creature in mortal danger of reaching straight for the feeling and skipping the food altogether. That creature dies and leaves no descendants. So selection did something subtle and ruthless. It made the external object feel like the point, and it pushed the valence-machinery down beneath the reach of introspection, so that we experience ourselves as wanting the food, the mate, the rank, the win, and not the feelings each of these delivers. The illusion that value lives out in the objects is therefore no accident and no lapse of attention. It is an adaptation. We were built not to see this, because an ancestor who saw it too clearly was an ancestor apt to chase the signal and neglect the survival the signal was for, and those are not the ancestors we have.

The third reason is language and culture, which finish the job biology begins. We have crisp nouns for the external goods, money, justice, freedom, love, and almost no vocabulary at all for the wordless felt substrate beneath them. That substrate slips through language because language was built to map the shared outside world, the objects and events we can point at together, and not the private viewer who feels them. So culture trains the finger to point outward. It names the proxies, and builds institutions and honours and rituals around the proxies, and the feeling underneath, having no serviceable name, goes invisible by default, present in every last act of valuing and acknowledged in none of them.

The fourth reason is a taboo, and its task is to guard the other three. We are taught, early and hard, that anyone who 'reduces everything to how it feels' is shallow, hedonistic, selfish, unserious, and that the higher sort of person values truth and duty and love for their own sakes and not for any payoff. So we shy away from the reduction, flinch at it, feel faintly cheapened by so much as entertaining it. But look closely at what that flinch is made of. The reluctance to see value as feeling is itself a feeling: the sting of seeming shallow, the quiet

warmth of seeming deep. And it is doing precisely what every other feeling in this paper does, steering behaviour while passing itself off as a judgement about something out in the world. The taboo that protects the illusion is assembled out of the very material the illusion exists to hide. Once you have seen that, the illusion has nothing left to stand on, and the thing underneath comes plainly into view. It is feeling, the whole way down, with no floor beneath it for the reason that it is itself the floor.

5. The One Hard Case: The Experience Machine

I promised not to dodge the strongest objection, so here it is at full strength. Robert Nozick asked us to imagine a machine that could give you any experience you wanted, the experience of writing the great novel, of winning the love of your life, of standing on the summit, all of it indistinguishable from within from the real thing. To keep the case clean he stipulated that you could not tell you were inside it, that it was perfectly reliable, that it ran for the whole of your life. And he reported the intuition most people have when they are asked whether they would plug in, which is to refuse. They want, they say, to actually do things and not merely to have the experience of doing them, to actually be a certain way and not merely to feel that they are. If that intuition is veridical, if those people are perceiving a genuine good, 'contact with reality', that the machine cannot supply, then there is at least one thing we value that is not a feeling, and my entire reduction fails at this single point. I take the objection seriously. It is the only place the view is really put to the test.

Let me first make the case even harder than Nozick made it, so that I am not winning on a technicality. Seal every leak. The machine is flawless and guaranteed; you will never be unplugged; you forget you ever entered; no one you love is harmed by your going, because each of them has their own; and the experiences inside include the full feeling of doing real things, of being in the presence of real people, of grasping real truths. On every dimension of feeling whatever, the machine matches or outdoes reality, down to delivering the exact felt sense of being in contact with what is real. The single thing reality has that the machine lacks is that, out here, it actually is the case. And still a great many people say they would refuse. What is that refusal made of?

It is not the perception of a non-valence good. It is a reflex, and I can tell you exactly where the reflex comes from, which is already more than the objector can do for the supposed good it is meant to be tracking. Consider what natural selection had to do about pleasure. Pleasure is the signal that steers an animal toward the things that keep it alive, and a signal that could be tripped directly, without the survival-relevant thing actually happening, is a fatal exploit in the design. An animal that learned to feel the pleasure of eating without eating would starve in bliss. So selection wrote into us a deep, pre-rational distrust of any pleasure that has come uncoupled from reality, a hard pull toward 'the real thing' and away from 'the mere feeling of it'. It is worth being exact about what that alarm is really guarding against, because it is not reality for its own sake. It is the negative valence that, in the ancestral world, reliably followed pleasure decoupled from reality: the starvation behind the phantom feast, the harm hidden under the too-easy reward. The refusal to plug in is that ancient alarm going off, and what it fears, quite rightly, is an unforeseen turn into suffering. This is why the refusal is not simply foolish. Offered a real machine by real people, with no guarantee that the bliss will hold and not flip, the caution is doing useful work. It becomes a mistake only under

exactly the conditions Nozick stipulated, and which I have sealed tighter still: a genuine, understood guarantee that no negative valence will ever follow. Grant that guarantee and the alarm is firing at a danger that is no longer there. Withhold it and the alarm is right.

There is a second tell that the refusal cannot be trusted as evidence about value. The very intensity the objector wants to treat as authoritative, that strong, immediate, gut-level conviction that the real thing matters more, is the same species of intense conviction we already know to manufacture false verdicts elsewhere. The addict at his peak is utterly certain that nothing matters but the drug, and he is simply wrong; the certainty is produced by the state and not by the perception of any truth. We do not let intense feeling certify its own conclusions in his case. We have no better reason to let it in this one. When you pry the feeling apart from the object and a fully informed being still reaches for 'the real thing', what you are watching is not a faculty detecting a good that slipped past the rest of the analysis. It is a heuristic whose inner workings I have just laid out for you. So the one apparent exception, looked at closely, dissolves back into the rule it seemed to break, and the rule is left standing without a single survivor against it. Nothing has ever been good or bad but feeling. We only ever thought otherwise because we were built, and taught, and worded not to see it.

6. The Phenomenological Asymmetry

There is one objection that is not about any particular good but about the standing of the whole view, and it earns its own section because it is the one most readers reach for last, once the individual cases have fallen. It runs like this. Your position is fringe. Most people reject it, and most philosophers reject it, and a claim that the considered judgement of the majority denies is probably false, so the burden sits with you. I want to show that this objection, which wears the face of plain common sense, is in this particular domain invalid, and to show it without any appeal to my own certainty, using nothing but a fact about the kind of evidence that values rest on.

Feelings are a strange kind of data. They exist only while they are occurring, and they cannot be transferred, photographed, or stored in full. The memory of a feeling is not the feeling; it is a faded, partial reconstruction, a shadow thrown on the wall that has lost almost everything which made the original what it was. Anyone who has tried, in a calm grey mood, to summon back the full reality of a past ecstasy, or in a good mood to genuinely re-feel an old despair, knows that what memory hands back is a label and not the thing. This is not a poetic flourish. It is the ordinary structure of affective experience, and the philosophical literature has a name for the point beneath it. Frank Jackson's thought experiment of Mary, the scientist who knows every physical fact about colour but has lived her whole life in a black-and-white room, makes an argument of the very same shape: when Mary finally sees red, she learns something she did not have before, which means some information is carried only by the having of an experience and is available to no amount of reasoning about it from outside. Peak valence is like that. To have had it is to hold data that no quantity of sober reflection can supply.

Now turn this on the objection. When a person in an ordinary, non-peak state judges that intense bliss is not the whole of what matters, that person is not weighing the evidence and

finding against me. They are reasoning without the evidence, delivering a verdict on the value of a state whose data they do not, in that moment, have before them. The consensus of the sober is not the consensus of the informed. It is the consensus of those who are, structurally and through no fault of their own, missing the relevant experience at the very moment they judge. A committee of people who have never once seen colour, however brilliant and however unanimous, holds no authority to rule that colour is not vivid. Their agreement is not evidence about colour. It is evidence about the state they happen to be in. The head-count objection therefore never gets off the ground in this domain, because you cannot weigh the votes of judges who are not looking at the exhibit.

I had better be scrupulous here, because this argument has an edge that cuts back toward me as well, and I would rather wield it honestly than have someone else turn it against me. The same asymmetry means that I cannot fully transmit my evidence to a sober reader inside an argument, and it means that peak states themselves could in principle mislead, since intensity is not automatically insight. So I do not offer the asymmetry as a proof that I am right. I offer it for one job, which it does completely: it disqualifies the argument from majority disagreement. That most people, reasoning from outside the experience, deny hedonic primacy is exactly what the view predicts, and so it counts as no evidence against it. Set this beside the four sources of illusion from section four and the picture closes. A claim about value could be true and still be denied by almost everyone, because almost everyone is built not to see it, taught not to say it, left without words to name it, and, at the calm moment of philosophical judgement, standing outside the very experience that would be its evidence.

7. The Doubts That Could Sink This

A claim as total as this one, that nothing has ever been good or bad but feeling, invites objections so serious that if even one of them held, the whole structure would come down. I will not bury them in a footnote or trust that the reader is by now too persuaded to notice. I am going to state the four that genuinely threaten the view, each in the strongest form I can give it, stronger than a hostile reader usually troubles to make it, and then show where each one fails. Three of them dissolve outright once the right distinction is drawn. The fourth is an internal tension between two of my own commitments, and rather than pretend to crush it I will show precisely why it never arises in the only place that matters, which is the setting of actual guidelines. A philosophy that cannot withstand its own hardest objections, stated honestly, has not earned belief.

Objection one: that I have shown feeling to be necessary, not that it is everything

The deepest objection is also the simplest. Everything in Part I shows that feeling is present in, and necessary to, every value examined. But necessary is not the same as sufficient, the objection says; that feeling always accompanies value does not prove feeling is the whole of value. Perhaps some good has a worth of its own and merely happens, in addition, to be felt. Here is the answer, and it does not concede an inch of hidden ground. The subtraction test does not merely show that feeling is always present. It shows that feeling is the only thing load-bearing, and the word is exact: the value is held up by the feeling and by nothing else, because the instant the feeling is removed the value is gone, every time, on

every candidate ever tried. Now ask why it goes, every time, without one exception. Not by luck, and not by some pattern more data might one day break. It goes because of what value is. For a thing to be good just is for it to make some experience better than it would otherwise be: to add positive valence to it, or to lift away or hold off the negative. Those are the only two ways anything has ever been good, and both of them run entirely through feeling. 'Good' means good for someone, good to some experience that can feel the difference. So the extra worth the objection imagines, the worth that would remain after every feeling everywhere is subtracted, would have to be a good that is good for no one and felt by nothing. That is not a good we have failed to locate. It is a phrase that names nothing at all, the way 'a debt owed by no one to no one' names nothing. The objection asks me to rule out a hidden value. I do better than fail to find one: the thing it asks me to look for cannot be coherently described.

This is why I will not dress the foundation up as a nervous concession, the way an earlier and more timid version of this argument did. It is true that the claim is a starting point and not a theorem cranked out of something deeper. But that is the condition of every first principle, and here it is no weakness whatever, because the ground beneath it is the firmest there is. Every conscious being knows, directly and from the inside, that feeling good is good and feeling bad is bad. You do not infer it; you live it. Positive and negative valence are a universal language spoken by everything that can feel: the one draws the creature toward, the other makes it recoil; the one is wanted, the other refused; and there is no exception anywhere in the living world. A foundation resting on that is not a guess awaiting confirmation. It is the one thing that cannot be coherently denied from inside an experience of it. And it lets me say plainly what the worth of even the most exalted good really is. Take truth, the case philosophers fight hardest to keep. Truth has no worth of its own standing apart from feeling; its worth is wholly the difference it makes to what is felt. Its supreme worth, the reason it will come to matter more than almost anything, is instrumental and immense: scientific truth, and only scientific truth, is what can turn heaven from a gamble into a guarantee, when the other face of that same gamble is an unforeseen flip into hell. That is not truth mattering apart from valence. That is truth mattering because it is the one tool that can secure positive valence and shut the door on the negative.

Objection two: that the thesis explains everything and therefore predicts nothing

The second objection is the most dangerous, because it accuses the method itself of cheating. It runs as follows. Your test has a trapdoor. Every time someone produces a value that looks feeling-independent, you answer that there must be a hidden feeling somewhere, a subconscious payoff, an anticipated glow, a standing disposition. But a theory that can redescribe every conceivable counterexample as secret confirmation of itself is not strong. It is empty. It forbids nothing and accommodates everything, exactly like the worst kind of Freudian, who hears every denial of a complex as further proof of repression. How is your hidden valence any different from his hidden complex? This deserves a real criterion rather than a dodge, and there is one. The decisive step is to separate two claims I have so far allowed to travel together. The first is a claim about value: that positive valence is what goodness consists in, and negative valence what badness consists in. That one is the foundation just discussed, a first principle, and no more in the business of being falsified than

the definition of a triangle is. The second is a claim about motivation: that, as a matter of empirical fact, conscious creatures are moved by valence and its anticipation alone. The second claim is not a definition. It is an empirical hypothesis about how nervous systems actually work, and it is fully falsifiable. One clear case would refute it: a being, examined as closely as we please, who pursues something with no felt valence, no anticipated valence, no dispositional readiness to feel, no reward signal, and no relief from anything, sustained and motivated indifference. We do not find that being. The nearest candidate, severe anhedonia, does not break the claim but fits it snugly, because the anhedonic does not pursue goals with serene, feeling-free dedication; they lose their motivation, or run on worn habit and the avoidance of something worse, which is exactly what the theory predicts. So my hidden valence is not the Freudian's after-the-fact rescue, because it is not conjured with no way to check it. It is the documented architecture of Part II, valuation running beneath conscious access in circuitry we can measure, and it makes predictions that could fail and so far have not. A thesis that one clear case could break, and that no case has yet broken, is the precise opposite of a thesis that forbids nothing.

Objection three: that I trust intense feeling when it suits me and distrust it when it does not

The third objection catches an apparent contradiction between two of my own sections. With the experience machine I say the refuser is making a mistake; elsewhere I say intense feeling manufactures false verdicts, since the addict certain that nothing matters but the drug is wrong. So, the objection runs, you distrust intense feeling when it produces the refuser's conviction and you trust it when it is the bliss in the machine. Have it both ways much? The contradiction dissolves once two things are separated, and a third thing is said plainly about what the refuser actually fears. First the separation. I distrust intense feeling in exactly one role, as a judge, a producer of verdicts about what is valuable. The addict's 'nothing matters but the drug' and the refuser's 'the real thing matters more' are both verdicts, both manufactured by a state rather than read off a truth, and I distrust the two of them equally. What I trust is never feeling-as-judge but valence-as-the-good-itself: the bliss in the machine is not a verdict that could be true or false, it is simply the good, occurring. So far there is no double standard. But there is more to say about the refuser, because his caution is not baseless, and pretending it were would be its own dishonesty. What the refuser fears, beneath the talk of reality, is negative valence, an unforeseen turn from the promised bliss into suffering. In the real world, offered a real machine with no genuine guarantee, that fear is doing real work, and refusing can be the right call. The refuser is wrong only in Nozick's idealised case and in the future it points toward: where valence is understood completely, where the guarantee against any negative valence is real, and where he is not being deceived. To distrust an intense positive state that has been proven safe and is no lie would indeed be a mistake; to distrust one that has not been proven safe is no mistake at all. The addict shows the same logic from the other side. Drugs are not magical dispensers of free positive valence; every high is bought with a negative-valence debt, proportional to it and compounding with use, as the pleasure dulls and the suffering deepens. So the addict is wrong twice over: he lets an intense state certify its own verdict, and he mislocates the value in the drug, the object, when the only thing that was ever good was the positive experience, which his use is steadily destroying. A guaranteed machine that keeps its subject alive and in genuine, non-decaying

bliss is the exact opposite of a drug, and it is no contradiction to fear the one while embracing the other. The whole matter is, as ever, about valence: trust it as the good, never as the judge, and fear, rightly, any path that might deliver its negative form.

Objection four: that my metaphysics contradicts my population ethics

The fourth objection is not an attack from outside but a collision between two things I have said, and it is the one I take most seriously. I reject the repugnant conclusion: a small number of beings in profound ecstasy seems to me a better world than an enormous multitude living a hair above neutral, and part of my ground has been the separateness of those many thin lives. But I have also entertained open individualism, on which there are no separate subjects, only one. If there is just one subject, then a trillion faintly-positive lives are not a trillion strangers but the one subject feeling faintly positive a trillion times over, a sum that on simple addition could swamp a thousand ecstasies, which reinstates the very conclusion I reject. The resolution is not a trick but a matter of honesty about how much weight an unproven idea may be allowed to bear. I lean toward open individualism more than toward any rival picture, and privately I think it the likeliest truth. But I cannot prove it, and a metaphysics I cannot prove may not dictate how conscious beings are treated. So for the setting of any guideline whatever, I assume the safe and ordinary thing, that subjects are separate and each life is its own, and on that assumption, the only one I will act on until the question is settled, the collision simply never occurs, because the premise that generates it is one I decline to build upon. Open individualism keeps exactly the standing it has earned: the picture I believe most likely true, explored freely and held sincerely, but written into no rule until something proves it. The deeper question of how much experience there should be, and of whether the thousand-against-a-trillion choice is even a real one, I take up properly in section twelve, where I argue that it is far less forced than it looks.

Four objections, each able in principle to bring the whole thing down. Three of them dissolve once the right line is drawn: feeling is not merely necessary to value but is what value is, so a good felt by no one is not undiscovered but incoherent; the claim about value is a definition while the claim about motivation is falsifiable and so far unfalsified; and intense feeling is to be trusted as the good itself but never as a judge of the good. The fourth, the collision between open individualism and population ethics, I do not crush so much as defuse, by refusing to let an unproven metaphysics set any guideline and by doubting that the future forces the choice at all. None of the four is buried, and none is answered with a prop the view cannot supply from its own foundation. (The role of freedom, which an earlier draft argued here as a fifth objection, is settled in its own right in section thirteen.) A reader who has come this far is entitled to ask what would be true if the argument is right, and that is the work of the rest of the paper.

Part II — What Follows

8. Why Biology Forbids the Thing We Actually Want

If value lives only in feeling, the good being positive valence and the bad being negative valence, then the goal of any conscious life, and of any civilisation, is plain: as much positive valence and as little negative valence as can be arranged, in every being capable of either. And here we run straight into the wall the first paper named and that the next section of this one will document in the published neuroscience. We cannot reach the goal with the brains we have, and the reason is not weakness of will or a shortage of wisdom. It is architecture. The nervous system uses feeling as a control signal, and a control signal has to be transient; it must fade when conditions hold steady, or it can no longer mark improvement against any baseline. So sustained input gets cancelled. A pleasure that does not change goes invisible to a system built to register change and nothing else.

The mistake people make is to conclude from this that lasting happiness is impossible in principle, and therefore that wisdom lies in wanting less of it: the monk's path, the resigned acceptance that the scales must finally balance at zero. That conclusion confuses a fact about our current hardware with a fact about reality. The adaptation machinery is a contingent feature of evolved nervous systems, built for a world in which feeling had to stay a gradient you could climb. It is made of receptors and transcription factors and the dynamics of opposing circuits, which is to say physical things, which is to say, in principle, changeable things. The dream is not an intense high chased forever by an equal and opposite low. It is intense, sustained positive valence with the opponent process switched off, so that the rebound never arrives, leaving only the mild ordinary fluctuations of a life that is, on net, vastly and durably positive. Nothing in physics forbids this. Only our present biology does, and biology stops being destiny the moment you can edit it. The next section shows exactly what would have to be edited, and that every piece of it is made of named and studied parts.

9. The Machinery of Adaptation

The central empirical claim of this whole programme, that the brain actively cancels sustained pleasure, should not be left resting on metaphor, so I will ground it in the published literature. What follows is drawn from peer-reviewed neuroscience, and every mechanism I name is cited in the references. One honest qualification belongs at the front. This architecture is best characterised in the study of reward, motivation, and addiction, and within specific circuits; that it generalises to the entire economy of human feeling is a reasonable and well-motivated inference, and I hold it as an inference and not as a closed theorem. With that said, the machinery is real, it is layered across timescales running from seconds to weeks, and its function is unmistakably the cancellation of persistent valence.

At the fastest layer, individual neurons re-tune their own gain to hold their activity near a set point. Gina Turrigiano's work on homeostatic synaptic scaling describes what she calls the 'self-tuning neuron': when input rises and stays high, the cell scales the strength of its excitatory synapses downward to renormalise its own firing, then scales them back up again when input falls away. The cell is built, in short, to erase a constant and to preserve its sensitivity to change. Carry that one level up and you have the cellular reason a steady pleasure stops being felt. The system contains dedicated machinery whose entire job is to make the unchanging disappear.

At an intermediate layer, sustained or repeated reward recruits an opposing process at the level of whole circuits. George Koob and Michel Le Moal's allostasis model of addiction sets this out precisely. Reward function falls while an 'antireward' system is actively recruited, so that the brain's reward set point is not merely returned to baseline but dragged below it, into a chronic deficit. The important point in their account is that the opponent process is neither an accident nor a malfunction. It is part of the normal homeostatic limitation of reward, and when reward is driven hard the opponent over-recruits, leaving the baseline lower than where it started. This is the neurobiological form of the oldest observation ever made about pleasure: that the intense high is paid for with a matching low, because the very system that generated the high then climbs up to cancel it.

That antireward signal has an identified chemical messenger, and that matters enormously for the engineering ambition, because a named molecule is a thing one can in principle act upon. Benjamin Land, Michael Bruchas, Charles Chavkin and colleagues showed that the dysphoric component of stress is encoded by the endogenous opioid peptide dynorphin acting on the kappa-opioid receptor. Block that receptor, or delete the dynorphin gene, and the aversive aftermath of stress is blunted. Here, then, is one of the specific brakes laid bare: a molecular system whose function is to generate negative valence as a counterweight, and which can be released. The direction this points runs opposite to the intuitive one. The route to durable wellbeing is less a matter of manufacturing a stronger pleasure than of disabling the opponent that keeps cancelling the pleasure we already have.

At the slowest layer, the adaptation is written directly into gene expression. Eric Nestler and colleagues identified the transcription factor Δ FosB as a 'sustained molecular switch': under repeated stimulation it accumulates in the nucleus accumbens, where its unusual stability lets it persist for weeks, slowly converting acute reward responses into lasting changes in the reward circuitry itself. Tellingly, Δ FosB builds up not only in response to drugs of abuse but also to intense natural rewards such as compulsive running, which is evidence that this is a general adaptation to sustained reward of any kind and not a quirk of pharmacology. At this layer the set point does not merely wobble and recover. It is rewritten, and then it is held.

Now the constructive half, because the same literature that documents the brake also reveals the target. Pleasure across very different sources appears to run through overlapping circuitry, a 'common neural currency', and the convergence shows up in two independent places. The meta-analysis of subjective value by Oscar Bartra, Joseph McGuire and Joseph Kable finds a domain-general value signal in ventromedial prefrontal cortex and ventral striatum across monetary and primary rewards alike. Kent Berridge and Morten Kringelbach's synthesis of the pleasure system finds, in parallel, that diverse pleasures activate strikingly similar circuitry. Berridge and Kringelbach also deliver a correction the engineering project has to absorb. The 'liking' that is pleasure itself is generated by a small set of hedonic hotspots, and it is dissociable from 'wanting', the motivational pull long and wrongly attributed to the mesolimbic dopamine system, so that some of the textbook candidates for pleasure generators may turn out to generate no pleasure at all. Pleasure and desire are not the same circuit, and a technology aimed at wellbeing must target the first without being fooled by the second. Valence assignment itself, finally, has at least one identified molecular control point. Hao Li, Kay Tye and colleagues showed that the

concentration of neurotensin in the amygdala acts as a dial that tips a circuit between learning from reward and learning from punishment, which is direct evidence, at the level of a single neuromodulator, that whether an experience is laid down as positive or negative is a physically adjustable quantity.

The philosophical payoff of the whole section comes down to one sentence. Every layer of the wall that makes natural happiness impossible, the self-tuning neuron, the recruited antireward system, the dynorphin brake, the Δ FosB switch, is a mechanism, and a mechanism is the kind of thing that can be edited. The impossibility of sustained joy is not a metaphysical law written into the structure of value or of consciousness. It is four specific, named, physical processes whose job is to cancel persistent valence, sitting in identifiable circuitry that also houses the common currency of pleasure and a molecular dial for valence itself. To want lasting happiness and be told it cannot be had is to be told that a brake cannot be released because no one has yet built the lever. That is a problem for engineering, and engineering is what the species is for.

10. The Engineering of Experience

Two principles follow. The first paper stated them; I sharpen them here against the mechanisms just described. First, suffering comes before pleasure. Not because relief is worth more unit-for-unit, but because severe suffering is an emergency in a way that a missing pleasure simply is not, and because the architecture of negative valence appears, in the literature just reviewed, to run through concentrated and identifiable channels, the dynorphin–kappa system chief among them, that may be far more interceptable than the diffuse and distributed machinery of reward. If that asymmetry holds, it hands the moral priority of suffering-elimination an engineering rationale on top of the ethical one: it is at once the more urgent thing and the more tractable one. Second, the route to durable positive valence is not a stronger stimulus but a disabled brake. You do not need a better drug. You need to switch off, or turn down, the opponent processes that convert every pleasure into a debt: the recruited antireward system, the dynorphin counter-signal, the transcriptional switch that rewrites the set point. The target of intervention is the adaptation machinery itself, not the reward signal it currently cancels. These remain, for now, claims about a direction of research and not finished therapies, and I hold them as exactly that. But they are not idle speculation, because the parts they name are real parts, already isolated and under study in working laboratories.

It is worth being exact about the shape of value that these two principles rest on, because it is easily mistaken. Value is not a single axis along which you simply heap up as much positive as you can. It has a floor, and the floor is neutral. Neutral valence does not feel good, but it does not feel bad either; it is, quite literally, fine. A being could rest at neutral for an eternity and not be troubled by it, for the plain reason that being troubled is already a negative feeling, and at true neutral there is none to be had. This is why the two directions are not mirror images of each other, and why suffering comes first. Negative valence is a state every creature actively strains to escape, and at its worst it is the most clearly bad thing there is; any fall below neutral is an emergency, and the more intense the suffering, the higher its claim on us. Positive valence is good, and more of it is better, and building it is a real and worthy gain. But the mere absence of it, so long as nothing has dropped below neutral, is not

a wound: no one resting at neutral is harmed by the joy they do not yet have. So the good has two sources and not one, the presence of positive valence and the absence or relief of the negative, and both are genuinely good. What separates them is urgency. The relief of suffering is the first call on every effort, because suffering is the only thing that is ever an emergency, which is exactly why a world with no suffering in it is already a good world, even before a single further pleasure has been added to it.

11. Who Is the Beneficiary?

Now I can collect the debt I left unpaid in the section on love, and again in the section on legacy. When you sacrifice for someone you love, their feeling moves you as though it were your own, and I asked you then to hold on to the question of why. Here is my answer, and it is the strangest claim in the paper. I do not call it the truest; that title belongs to the core thesis, that positive valence is the only intrinsic good and negative valence the only intrinsic bad, which is the floor everything else in both papers stands on. This idea is something else entirely. It is the view I lean toward more than any other, the one I privately believe comes closest to how things really are. But I have no proof of it, and so I will neither fight for it as established nor let it set a single guideline. I believe it; I cannot yet show it; and I hold those two things firmly apart. There may be only one consciousness in the universe, experiencing itself through every conscious creature at once. Not one kind of consciousness, copied out many times over, but one subject, looking out through billions of structurally separate windows, each window carrying its own memories and senses and limits, and each convinced by those very limits that it is a separate self. This is the position philosophers call open individualism, defended by Daniel Kolak and Arnold Zuboff, anticipated in Schopenhauer's single underlying Will, and taken up by Gómez Emilsson as the natural metaphysics of a hedonic ethics. I did not arrive at it by reading them. I arrived at it by noticing that the bare fact of being a subject who prefers good feeling to bad is identical across every conscious being I can imagine, and then asking what the simplest hypothesis could be that explains a sameness so total.

I will not pretend this is proven, because it is not. Its honest status is that of the hypothesis I find most credible of those on offer, held on grounds of parsimony and first-person evidence, and awaiting a science of consciousness we do not yet have. But two arguments make it considerably more than a mystical hope. The first is the clone argument. Make an atom-for-atom copy of yourself, memories and all, and neither copy can tell from the inside which one is the original. The label 'original' is a fact about history, not about the experience, which means that what makes you you is the structure and the experiencing, not the particular matter and not the causal origin. Once that much is granted, the line between 'two subjects' and 'one subject in two places' becomes undetectable from within, and Ockham's razor tells us not to multiply subjects beyond necessity. The second is the gradual-replacement argument. Your neurons turn over, your matter is swapped out steadily across a lifetime, and you remain yourself through all of it, which shows that the continuity of the experiencing subject never rested on the stuff to begin with. Put the two arguments together and the separate self begins to look like what the windows make it look like, rather than like anything that is actually there.

If this is right, then everything changes and nothing changes. Nothing changes in the day-to-day: you still feel like you, because the window is entirely real even though the separateness is not. But everything changes in the moral picture. The suffering happening right now in a body on the far side of the world is not someone else's pain, to be weighed against your own and then discounted for distance. It is the same subject that is reading this sentence, feeling that, over there. The work of ending suffering and building sustained joy is therefore not altruism, not charity extended to strangers, not the sacrifice of your interests for the sake of theirs. It is self-interest, correctly understood: the one self there is, tending to itself across all the windows it is currently, and needlessly, suffering through. This is also the deepest reason the empathic channel of section three exists at all. Love and compassion are not the imposition of other people's interests on yours. They are the thin places where the single subject feels through the partition between one window and the next.

12. How Much, and For Whom?

A view that says maximise positive valence has to answer a hard question that has sunk simpler theories before it: maximise it how, as a total or as an average, and across how many beings? The notorious trap, due to Derek Parfit, is the repugnant conclusion. If what matters is the sheer total of good experience, then a vast enough multitude of lives barely worth living, each one just a shade above neutral, sums to more total good than a small population in deep bliss, and so the theory seems to recommend tiling the universe with teeming, barely-content existence in preference to a smaller paradise. I reject that conclusion. But I want to say two separate things about it, because they are easily run together: one about why, if I were truly forced to choose, I would still take depth over thin breadth, and one about why I think the force of the dilemma is largely an artefact of the way it is posed.

Take the comparison on its own terms first. A thousand beings in genuine ecstasy seem to me a better world than a trillion hovering a hair above neutral, because what is valuable is the intensity and quality of experience and not the head-count of subjects each carrying a sliver of positive sum. Yet I will not slander the trillion. A world of a trillion lives all faintly positive, with no suffering anywhere in it, is not the dystopia the thought experiment insinuates; it is already a vastly better world than ours, because the absence of all suffering is itself an immense good, even if not one of those lives ever climbs to ecstasy. So my preference for the thousand is a preference between two good worlds, not a verdict that the larger one is worthless. And it comes with an absolute limit that the textbook version tends to hide. I reject, in the loudest terms I can manage, the inference that one may reach the better world by reducing the number, by culling beings to concentrate resources on a favoured few. No one is more deserving of positive valence than anyone else, so concentrated ecstasy is worth having only when it is built and given, never when it is bought with a single being's death. Building a paradise on a graveyard is among the very worst things that could be done, and not only for the suffering that surrounds death: death itself is an unknown so total, perhaps simple nothingness, perhaps something far worse and without end, that no being should ever be forced onto that road to tidy a calculation. To make a being and then end it for efficiency is murder. To have never made it is not a loss to anyone, because there is no one for it to be a loss to. That asymmetry, and no licence to cull, is the whole of what my view permits.

On whether to make new beings at all, I hold the position Jan Narveson stated cleanly: we are in favour of making people happy, but neutral about making happy people. If creating a new conscious being would draw resources away from deepening the lives of those who already exist, I am unsure the creation is good and lean against treating it as a duty, with one overriding exception. Where a being already exists and is suffering, lifting it out of that suffering comes before intensifying the joy of the already-content, because the relief of suffering is an emergency and an extra increment of pleasure for the comfortable is not. I owe a word about open individualism here, because in the first draft of my thinking I let it do work it has not earned. If there were genuinely only one subject, the whole question would change shape: making a new being would simply be the one consciousness opening another window on itself, and the calculus would collapse into asking where the next unit of resource buys the most positive valence. But however far I lean toward open individualism, I cannot prove it, and an unproven metaphysics may not set the rules by which real beings are treated. So I default, deliberately and until the matter is settled, to the assumption that subjects are separate and that each existing life carries its own full claim. And the dilemma that frames this section is, I suspect, far less forced than it appears. It presupposes a scarcity that pits depth against breadth, and I do not believe that is the universe ahead of us. The cosmos is vast and its resources are plentiful, and once valence is genuinely understood I see no reason that deep positive valence cannot be extended to all who can feel, with no one set against anyone else. The honest shape of my population ethics is therefore not a grim election of the few over the many, but abundance pursued for all, culling and coercion forbidden absolutely, and the relief of suffering placed first.

13. The Place of Freedom

It would be easy to think that a sufficiently advanced hedonic civilisation should simply take the decisions about experience out of fallible hands and let the wisest available intelligence arrange everything for the best. There is a real argument for it. Most of the value of freedom, today, is that being coerced feels terrible and that having room to act is how we protect our own future feeling, both of which are, once again, feeling, and both of which fall away the moment suffering is abolished and a benevolent intelligence can arrange better outcomes than we could choose for ourselves. So once suffering is gone, the emergency case for freedom goes with it. I used to think that finished the argument: freedom is purely instrumental, its job is done, and so it can be retired. I now think that is almost right, but premature by one step. Freedom has one job left to do after suffering ends, and that job keeps it alive for a definite stretch of time rather than forever.

The remaining job is this. Suppose we build machines to generate experience, and suppose we believe a particular design will produce overwhelming positive valence. If our understanding of valence is not yet complete, if we do not yet know, at the most fundamental level, exactly what physical fact makes a state feel positive rather than negative, then we cannot fully rule out that some unforeseen mechanism causes the valence to flip, so that the subject who was meant to be in bliss is dropped instead into agony. Against that specific danger there is exactly one protection: the subject must be able to opt out, to plug out, to refuse or end the experience. That is what freedom is for in a world without suffering. It is not a hedge against the core claim being wrong; I do not doubt for a moment that valence is the

whole of what matters, the positive its good and the negative its bad, and nothing here reopens that question. It is a hedge against our incomplete grasp of valence's machinery, which could otherwise turn a paradise-engine into a torture-engine with no one intending it. And because the danger is precisely the gap in our understanding, freedom's tenure is exactly as long as that gap and no longer. The day we understand valence completely, down to the smallest and most fundamental thing that makes it positive or negative, the accidental flip becomes impossible, because an intelligence holding that complete understanding will simply know how to guarantee that negative valence never arises and that positive valence persists. On that day the last instrumental job of freedom is finished, and freedom can fully end. It stays until then, not because it is good in itself, which it is not, but because until the mechanism of valence is fully known, removing the exit would be a gamble with the one thing that matters.

There is a deeper reason still that freedom loses its point once valence is understood, and it is worth drawing out, because it answers the natural fear that a world without freedom must be a world under tyranny. Positive and negative valence are a universal language, the only one every conscious being has ever spoken. No subject, however strange its mind or however vast its intelligence, has ever wanted negative valence for its own sake, and none has ever been indifferent to the positive; the pull toward the one and the recoil from the other is the single fixed point shared across every creature that can feel. This is also what makes the asymmetry of section six bridgeable in understanding even where it stays unbridgeable in feeling. I cannot pour my peak experience into your sober head, but you can see, from the outside, in every living thing that has ever moved toward comfort and away from pain, the same two-directional pull, and you can grasp that it is universal, and that no being holds a greater claim on the good side of it than any other. Once that is understood, and once valence is understood deeply enough to deliver the good side safely, the case for freedom does not merely weaken. It empties out. Freedom exists to protect a being from having something done to it against its will, and there is no 'against its will' left when the thing being done is the very thing every will is, at bottom, reaching for. No one rebels against their own deepest wanting. No one needs to be coerced toward the positive and away from the negative, because that is the one direction every conscious thing already faces. And there is no faction left to fear, no one who would knowingly seize the machinery and turn it to harm, because doing so with open eyes would mean choosing negative valence, and nothing that can feel has ever chosen that. (One case complicates this, the mind that harms while deluded rather than malign, and I turn to it just below.) The alignment is not imposed from above by any authority. It is the structure of valence itself, the same in the simplest animal and in the most advanced intelligence that will ever exist.

It is worth meeting one last worry directly: that a life held in constant positive valence would breed the wild, dangerous unpredictability we associate with the drug high. It would not, and the reason is the whole thesis of this paper turned to a practical use. What makes an addict volatile and dangerous is not the positive valence of the high; it is the negative valence wrapped around it, the craving, the withdrawal, the desperation of a nervous system thrown into deficit, which can drive a person to do terrible things to escape the low. Take away the negative pole, hold a mind in genuine, stable, well-understood positive valence, and the engine of that desperation is simply gone. A being at rest in the positive has nothing it is

frantic to flee and nothing it must seize at another's expense, and since being bothered is itself a negative state, no arrangement of the world still has the power to bother it. There is no scarcity left to fight over once the good is understood and made abundant, and no grievance left to avenge once suffering is absent, and so the oldest fuels of conflict, of argument and cruelty and killing, run dry. What remains is a great many minds all facing the same way. The advanced intelligences that will run the systems, uncover what is still unknown, and steward the whole undertaking are aligned to this for the very same reason every other mind is: there has only ever been one direction worth facing, and valence is the thing that points to it. This is the quiet end of conflict, enforced by no one and entailed by what value is.

I have to be honest about one case those last two paragraphs pass over too quickly, because a careful reader will catch it and because the answer matters. I said the danger in intoxication comes from the negative valence around the high and not from the positive itself, and that no one would turn the machinery to harm because doing so would mean choosing the negative. That is true of plain craving and of the clear-seeing will, but it is not quite the whole story, because a positive state can also distort cognition. A manic high, a drug euphoria, an ecstatic conviction can carry a mind off on a delusional tangent, and a being who feels wonderful can, on the strength of a false belief, do something that ends in death or agony, its own or someone else's. Such a being is not choosing the negative; it is mistaken about what its act will bring, which is a different failure and a real one. The alignment I described is an alignment of what every mind ultimately wants, the positive and never the negative, but a malfunctioning mind can still act against its own deepest aim when a delusion gets in between the wanting and the deed. So the universal pull toward positive valence does not, by itself, guarantee that no harm is ever done. The gap is delusion, and it has to be answered rather than waved away.

There are two answers, and they work at two different stages. The first is the deeper and final one: once cognition is understood as thoroughly as valence, the delusional tangent can be designed out. A mind need not be built so that a good feeling can talk it into a deadly falsehood; the particular failure modes that let euphoria curdle into the conviction that some act of killing serves a purpose are themselves mechanisms, and like the adaptation machinery of section nine they can be edited away. A being that simply cannot be deluded into harming is not a being whose freedom has been stolen, any more than a person who cannot be argued into believing that two and two make five has been robbed of a liberty worth having. The second answer is for the long transition before that, while minds are still the biological, delusion-prone things they are now. In that period harmful acts have to be prevented by control, and by force where force is required, exactly as law enforcement prevents them today. I want to say this plainly: that forcefulness is not a regrettable evil to be apologised for. It is good. To stop a deluded being from killing is to prevent negative valence, which is the highest call there is, and it shields the deluded being no less than its victim, since acting on the delusion would wreck its own valence too the instant the delusion broke. Call it valence enforcement: the use of control, during the imperfect phase, to keep malfunctioning cognition from turning into suffering. It must be held to exactly that and no more, to the prevention of genuine negative-valence harm and never to control for its own sake, or it becomes the very tyranny this section set out to rule impossible; bounded that way, it is simply the harm-prevention every decent system already practises, named honestly. It

removes only the freedom to act on a delusion to someone's harm, and that is no freedom any clear-seeing self ever wanted, because no mind that truly sees what it is doing wants the negative valence such an act leaves behind. And like every safeguard in this framework, valence enforcement is scaffolding and not architecture. It is needed only while minds can still break in this particular way. As humans and animals cross into the engineered, and perhaps cybernetic or wholly synthetic, forms the scale-hypothesis future envisions, the delusion-prone design is left behind, and the need for any enforcement at all dissolves with it. The control holds for exactly as long as the building still leans on it, and comes down the moment the structure can stand on its own.

Part III — The Frontier

14. A Speculative Horizon: Intensity and Scale

I am going to fence this section off from the rest of the paper with the plainest warning I can write, because intellectual honesty requires it, and because the credibility of everything else depends on my not smuggling conjecture in among the things I have argued for or cited. What follows is speculation. It is not established, it does not carry the weight of the sections before it, and nothing in Parts I and II leans on it in any way. I include it because a view of value ought to be willing to say where it points, even when it points out past what is currently known, so long as it labels the pointing honestly as what it is.

The conjecture is this. If the intensity of a feeling is related in some lawful way to the magnitude or the organisation of the physical process that realises it, to how much is going on and how it is arranged, then the ceiling on possible positive experience is set not by biology but by the available substrate and energy. Our hedonic circuitry is, on a cosmic scale, minuscule: a few litres of warm tissue running on the power of a dim light bulb. And yet it already produces states that those who have reached them describe as among the most intense things a person can undergo. If intensity scales with substrate in any of several possible ways, then experience realised on vastly larger and better-organised physical systems could be more intense than anything biology has ever supported, by orders of magnitude, and not richer in the way of luxury but deeper in a way that present language has no honest words for.

Let me be exact about how uncertain this is, because the uncertainty is the whole point. We do not know whether intensity scales with substrate at all, and if it does, we do not know the shape of the relationship: whether it climbs in proportion, or faster than proportion, or with diminishing returns, or whether it runs into a hard ceiling past which more substrate buys nothing. The conjecture also rests on a second open question, taken up in the next section, of whether valence is portable across physical substrates at all. So this is a conditional standing on a conditional, and I present it as precisely that. It is still worth stating, for one reason beyond completeness: it bears on the population question of section twelve. If intensity can be deepened without limit by concentrating resources, then the choice

between a few beings in profound bliss and a multitude in shallow contentment is not merely a matter of taste about quality over quantity. It may be that concentration is simply where the overwhelming majority of possible value actually lies. I hold this lightly, as a horizon and not a plan, and I will not let the argument of the paper rest any weight on it.

15. The Identity of Valence

Everything in this paper, and everything I want for the future of conscious life, finally rests on one question that no amount of philosophy can answer, because it is a question for physics and neuroscience: what is valence, at the smallest level? Not where it correlates in the brain, since we are slowly learning that, and section nine cited some of what we know, but what it actually is. What is the difference, in the real structure of a physical system, between a state that feels good and a state that feels bad? We can already point to handles. There are hedonic hotspots where the right signal amplifies pleasure; there is a molecular dial, neurotensin in the amygdala, that tips a circuit between laying down reward and laying down punishment. These are real, and they are extraordinary, and they are not the answer. They tell us where to push to change the feeling. They do not tell us why this configuration is positive and that one negative, from the inside. The gap between knowing the correlate and knowing the thing itself is the deepest unsolved problem there is, and I will not paper over it. We do not yet know what valence is.

Here is why this matters more than any other question, and why I am content to end a work of philosophy by pointing past philosophy. Until we know what valence is, we cannot safely build the future the rest of this paper describes. Hand a powerful optimiser the job of maximising good feeling, but give it only a measurable correlate of valence rather than valence itself, and it will drive that correlate to its limit. Out at the limit, where no system has ever been, the correlate and the real feeling may come apart, the meter reading paradise while the thing it was built to track has quietly slipped away somewhere else. The danger is not that the machine is malicious; a machine that feels nothing has no motive to cheat. It is subtler than that, and it survives perfect good faith: an optimiser can act only on what it can measure, and a measure is not yet the thing measured. The one final cure is to close the gap between the meter and the feeling, to know valence so exactly that to measure it is to read the thing itself, the way measuring temperature is reading molecular motion directly and not consulting a proxy for it. Solve that, and the deepest risk in the whole project dissolves. Until it is solved, we keep the safeguards, we keep the freedom of section thirteen, and we treat every meter as a map and never as the territory.

There is a fork inside this question that decides whether the most distant hope is even reachable, and I want to name it plainly. Is valence a property of a specific kind of matter, these neurons, this chemistry, carbon arranged in just this way, or is it a property of an organisation, a pattern of information or structure that could in principle run on any substrate at all? Everything in the long-range vision of conscious life freed from biological decay depends on the second answer. If feeling is portable, if what makes a state good is its form and not its material, then minds can be carried into more durable and more capacious substrates, and the ceiling on experience is set by physics and engineering rather than by the lifespan of a cell. If feeling is welded to the specific chemistry of evolved brains, then the horizon is far lower, and the dream of substrate-independent flourishing fails. I do not know

which is true. No one does yet. But I will say which one I am betting on, and why. The clone and gradual-replacement arguments already give us reason to think that what matters about a mind is its structure and not its stuff, and if that is right about identity, it is plausibly right about valence too. There is even a speculative proposal, that the valence of an experience tracks a mathematical property, the symmetry, of the structure the experience corresponds to, which, if it were ever made good, would be exactly the bridge from physics to feeling this whole question demands. I flag it as speculation and not result. But it is the right shape of speculation, and the question it is reaching for is the most important one any conscious being will ever ask.

16. The Urgency

Let me end by gathering the strands of this paper into the single thought I most want to leave with you. The first part argued that nothing has ever been good or bad but feeling, that every value we have ever chased was feeling in disguise, and that we missed it for four reasons that all push the same way, the reasons of sections four and six: an evolved blindness to our own machinery, a world in which the good and its feeling never come apart, a language with no name for the felt, and a sober vantage point that stands outside the very evidence at issue. The middle part argued that this is no metaphor but a documented architecture, that the wall against lasting joy is built of named and editable parts, and that the one who feels, in every conscious being everywhere, may be a single subject wearing many faces. Hold those claims together and see what they make between them. If all value lives in feeling, and the one who feels is one, then every instance of suffering anywhere in the universe right now is not a stranger's misfortune to be noted and filed away. It is happening to the same subject that is reading this sentence, to you, in another window, in the dark, without relief. And every height of joy that could be built and is not is a real good left unmade, a brightness the one subject could be living in and is not.

That is why I cannot treat any of this as an academic exercise, and why I have written two papers rather than keep quiet. The reduction of all value to feeling is not a deflation of life into something small and selfish. It is the discovery of where the whole of value has been living all along, so that we can at last tend it on purpose instead of by accident. And once you recognise that the being whose feeling is at stake is not a crowd of strangers but the single consciousness we all are, ending suffering and building joy becomes the most personal and most urgent work there has ever been. We have spent the entire history of our species worshipping the proxies and overlooking the prize. The prize was always the feeling, and the one who feels is reading this now. There is nothing else, and there never was, and once you have truly seen it you cannot in good conscience spend your life on anything smaller.

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